> postcolonial critique of Orientalism, but much less informed about the theorization of Occidentalism or Americanity.

This is yet another reason why the decolonial approach is better than the postcolonial in the critical realm of religion, since the latter privileges modern secularism without exploring or acknowledging its Christian OET foundations and applies the construct of ‘religion’ as well as ‘secularism’ to native OET systems. According to Balagangadhara, De Roover and Sarah Claerhout,[15] the application of this framework can be traced to the Christian premise ‘that religion would exist among all nations, because God had gifted religion to humanity at the time of creation’. In fact, these scholars take the considered position that the application of Christian theology led to misplaced deductions which pass off as historical facts, such as ‘Brahmins are the priests of Hinduism’ or ‘Buddhism was a reform movement against Brahmanism and its caste hierarchy’. The following is a relevant excerpt from a paper by Dr. Roover and Claerhout,[16] which captures the decolonial question in the realm of ‘religion’:

> One could simply accept that ‘Hinduism’ does not name a unitary phenomenon, but picks out a super set that includes many different sets of practices and beliefs.... One could even add that the claim that Hinduism cannot be one religion, because it is not a coherent unit, presupposes a Christian model of religion as a coherent doctrinal entity and then assesses Hinduism according to this model.
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> Did Indians, with their own background framework and cultural experience, understand what the British meant when the latter said ‘religion’, ‘law’, ‘scripture’, ‘priests’ or ‘caste’? Did the British and other Europeans, with their specific background framework and cultural experience, understand Indians when they spoke of ‘dharma’, ‘shastra’, ‘puja’, ‘brahmanas’ or ‘jati’?
>
> Whenever Europeans invoked notions like ‘religion’, ‘worship’, ‘gods’ or ‘priesthood’ in order to describe India, their reasoning operated against a background theology, which had determined the semantic content and systematic relations of these terms. Over many centuries, this background theology had shaped natural language use in European vernaculars. Naturally, Indians had their own cultural experiences, linguistic practices and semantic schemes. Trying to make